

MEN. MASCULINITIES. AND CHANGING POWER

A DISCUSSION PAPER ON
ENGAGING MEN IN GENDER
EQUALITY FROM BEIJING
1995 TO 2015



MenEngage

boys and men for gender equality

DEFINITIONS

Gender refers to the socially constructed attributes and roles associated with being male or female. These attributes and roles define what is expected, allowed, and valued in women and men. Gender is neither invariable nor biologically determined—it changes over time and across settings. Individuals learn and internalize gender-related attributes and roles from families and friends, in schools, communities, religious and cultural institutions, and from the media. Because gender is part of the broader socio-cultural context, it is experienced and expressed differently across various social identities, including political status, class, ethnicity, physical and mental disability, age, and other social classifications.¹²

Masculinity is the particular pattern of social behaviors or practices that is associated with ideals about how men should behave and their position withingender relations. Masculinity is a relational concept, defined in opposition to femininity and expectations about how women should behave (White). One of the more common features of masculinity is the equation of manhood with dominance, toughness, and risk-taking. However, as with femininities, there are multiple masculinities, which change over time and between and within settings.¹³ Some of these masculinities may hold more power and privilege than others: some may be considered exemplary; some may be socially marginalized.¹⁴

Power includes the ability to make decisions about one's life and the capacity to influence and/or effect desired goals. All relationships are affected by the exercise of power, which in turn is profoundly shaped by social identities, including gender, race, class, sexual orientation, age, religion, nationality, etc. Gender inequalities are defined by "power over," or controlling forms of power, whereas efforts to increase women's empowerment and promote gender equality seek to promote alternative forms of power: power to, power with, and power from within, which focus on using individual and collective strengths to work towards common goals without coercion or domination.¹⁵

Gender equality is about transforming the ways individuals experience and express power in their lives, relationships, and communities, and the power structures that shape the relations between women and men. It involves increasing individual autonomy and self-efficacy, and ensuring that individuals have equal opportunities to make choices in their lives and to participate in key domains of society.¹⁶ Although gender equality is most often associated with the advancement and empowerment of women, it is a much broader enterprise that seeks to advance societies as a whole by ensuring that, as noted by the Special Rapporteur on extreme poverty and human rights, "all human beings can develop and make choices without the limitations set by stereotypes, rigid gender roles, and prejudices."¹⁷ To this end, moving toward gender equality also entails supporting individuals whose identities do not fit within the traditional gender binary.^{*} Although it is important to frame the significance and impact of gender equality broadly, we cannot lose sight of the fact that women and girls bear the brunt of gender inequalities. Throughout the world,

- Men's continued use of **coercion and violence against women** in private and public spheres, at individual and aggregate levels, is perhaps the starkest example of how these power

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^{*} Discussions about gender equality often frame gender as a binary between men and women, thereby reinforcing the misperception that all people identify with the gender they were assigned at birth. Transgender individuals, however, challenge this notion. The transgender spectrum encompasses a wide range of individuals, including transgender men, not assigned male at birth but who, like transgender women, may seek to transition socially and/or medically (a process to affirm their gender identities). It may also refer to gender non-conforming individuals who identify outside of the gender binary, and who may not be entirely comfortable with the labels of male or female (National Center for Transgender Equality, NCTE). In discussing gender-related power imbalances, it is therefore important to consider the additional layer of power imbalance between transgender and non-transgender individuals, whereby trans-identities are often stigmatized and transgender people made the targets of violence and legal, social, and economic subjugation (NCTE).

imbalances affect women's lives and agency.

- Within family settings in some developing countries, **men still often have the final say regarding the use of household resources**, women's and girls' health decisions, their physical mobility, and their access to educational opportunities.¹⁸
- In many settings, **men's unequal participation in family care work** and household tasks continues to be a barrier to women's work-life balance and their economic and other public endeavors.¹⁹ At even broader levels, men are still the **vast majority of leaders in government and the private sector** and maintain control of policy agendas and investment decisions that shape women's access and opportunities (as they also shape the access and opportunities that low income and less powerful women and men have).²⁰

Gender inequalities are constructed and perpetuated by unequal and unjust power relations between men and women, as well as among men and among women. **Truly transforming gender relations therefore entails addressing how rigid gender norms affect power relations between men and women as well as among men and among women.** Looking at how women's lives as well as men's are shaped not only by gender but also by other power differentials based on age, class, ethnicity, nationality, caste, religion, sexual orientation, and other social identities helps get us past the limitations of binaries to better understand the many textures and realities of men's and women's lives.²¹

While men usually have more agency than women in their lives, men's decisions and behaviors are also profoundly shaped by rigid social and cultural expectations

*related to masculinity, as well as by power imbalances which have costs for both them and the women and girls in their lives.*²² Throughout the world, gender roles compromise men's health by encouraging them to equate being "manly" with various risky behaviors, from multiple sexual partners and alcohol consumption to the use of physical aggression and the unwillingness to seek health services or emotional support. In addition to the obvious implications for men's own health and well-being, these behaviors—as in the case of unsafe sex and alcohol abuse—have grave consequences for the women and children in men's lives.

*For some men, the consequences of not conforming to certain masculine norms can also involve social ostracism and violence.*²³ Homophobia is a particularly salient and pervasive example of how narrow conceptions of manhood can shape power relations between men. In many settings around the world, homophobia is a central organizing principle in male socialization and is used as a means to keep boys and men "in line".²⁴ To identify or imply that a man or boy is not heterosexual is to impose "a label of ultimate contempt for anyone who seems sissy, untough, uncool".²⁵ From an early age, boys are often faced with the continual threat of being identified as gay if they stray from certain expectations of masculine behavior. Often, the label is accompanied by verbal bashings and physical aggression. Men who are, in fact, gay or who are perceived as gay often experience various forms of oppression and abuse at the hands of other men. Another widespread expression of masculine domination and violence over other men is the deliberate use of rape and various forms of humiliation in military, prison, and war contexts.²⁶

Further, while men as a group benefit from the association of masculinity and privilege and hold greater power than women, not all men are powerful.

Many men, particularly low-income and minority men, are marginalized and subordinated by traditional power structures.²⁷ The fact that many of the world's poorest men are also disempowered—albeit in different ways from women—compared to men with more income and better social positions is nearly always left out of gender analyses and discussions but is a central issue in terms of how men view their own sense of power, and whether they view themselves as allies or beneficiaries of gender equality. As Connell writes, "Class, race, national, regional, and generational differences cross-cut the category 'men,' spreading the gains and costs of gender relations very unevenly among men".²⁸ Men's experiences of powerlessness are harmful not only for them but also for the women in their lives. Studies have found, for example, that men's frustration with their perceived lack of power can lead them to adopt certain behaviors that give them a sense of power over others, including high-risk sexual behaviors and violence against female partners.²⁹ In contrast, however, there are also many situations where groups of men who feel disadvantaged by the existing power structures see their interest as more closely aligned with the women in their communities than with other men.³⁰ This reminds us that "men respond very diversely to gender-equality politics" and that power inequalities in gender relations must be considered in the context of broader power inequalities in society.³¹

While it is important to acknowledge that rigid gender norms carry costs for men and boys, we also need to be careful about how we articulate these costs in the broader context of

the gender equality agenda. *In short, gender inequalities fall overwhelmingly on women and girls. At the same time, the lives of men and boys are affected by gender and gender-related power inequalities that interact with other social inequalities. Rather than negating each other, there is a need to accept and understand that both of these are true and related.* In discussing the broad-reaching costs of gender norms, the intention is not to emphasize false parallels or equate men's and women's experiences of gender-related inequalities and violence.³² Nor is the intention to minimize men's stake in gender equality to their own interests such that we detract from the fact that women's struggle for gender justice is central to efforts for gender equality.³³ Rather, broadening the discussion about how gender norms affect both women and men helps us to better understand the many and complex ways that rigid gender norms and power relations burden our society and to more effectively engage men and boys in reflections about inequalities and change.³⁴

THE GLOBAL CONFERENCES OF CAIRO (1994) AND BEIJING (1995) AND WHAT THEY MEAN FOR MEN, MASCULINITIES, AND CHANGING GENDER RELATIONS

The key role of men and boys in achieving gender equality emerged as an issue in international discussions in the 1990s, most notably at the 1994 International Conference on Population and Development (ICPD) in Cairo and the 1995 Fourth World Conference on Women in Beijing. The landmark documents that came out of the Cairo and Beijing conferences were driven by strong feminist movements and expressly recognized that women's empowerment and gender equality are central to achieving greater social justice,

peace and security, and sustainable development. They were also significant for drawing specific attention to the need to work with men and boys in promoting women's empowerment and gender equality. *Prior to Beijing and Cairo, major policy discussions and documents regarding gender equality had dedicated limited, if any, attention to the role of men and boys.* (But see Box 2 on CEDAW). If and when men and boys were featured in policy documents and discussions, it was often as the implied or named obstacles to women's struggle for equality—rarely were they identified as a potential or necessary part of the solution.³⁵

In the Beijing Declaration, governments expressed a commitment to "encourage men to participate fully in all actions towards equality".³⁶ This language and commitment marked a concerted shift in international discourse toward actively acknowledging and engaging men and boys as an integral part of achieving gender equality. *Beyond just the nominal or symbolic involvement of men, the Beijing framework envisioned male engagement as a necessary means to addressing inequalities between women and men.* The Beijing Platform for Action (BPfA) emphasizes the need for a "transformed partnership" between women and men, one based on "the principle of shared power and responsibility... at home, in the workplace and in the wider national and international communities".³⁷ Additionally, the BPfA identifies various critical areas of public and private life where more attention to male engagement, in terms of redressing work and power balance, is needed, including but not limited to: (1) education, (2) socialization of children, (3) child care and housework (e.g., unpaid and paid care work), (4) sexual and reproductive health, (5) gender-based violence, and (6)